RELIGION WITHOUT GOD

DEFINITION TEST → CRITERIA AND FUNCTIONS → FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS → BUDDHISM → JAINISM → MĪMĀṂSĀ → SĀṂKHYA-YOGA → CĀRVĀKA AS THE LIMIT → WESTERN CRITIQUE AND POST-THEISM → MODERN NON-THEISTIC RELIGION → SYNTHESIS

Read the numbered rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis at Stage 14. Each card uses an internal layout chosen for its own content: a definition fork, graded matrices, a function ledger, causal chains, argument panels, hierarchies and a closing synthesis spine. The grey E card is subordinate optional enrichment and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW · ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA · ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • in-place repair; all prior artifacts unchanged outside this topic

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00 · STAGE 00 THE NECESSITY QUESTION AND THE DEFINITION THAT DECIDES IT

IS A PERSONAL CREATOR NECESSARY FOR RELIGION? · NOT THE EXISTENCE QUESTION · SUBSTANTIVE — BY ITS OBJECT · FUNCTIONAL — BY WHAT IT DOES · MULTIDIMENSIONAL — SMART'S SEVEN · FAMILY RESEMBLANCE — NO SHARED ESSENCE · TOO NARROW = QUESTION-BEGGING · TOO BROAD = EMPTY CATEGORY · NON-THEISTIC IS NOT ATHEISTIC

IS BELIEF IN A PERSONAL CREATOR NECESSARY FOR RELIGION?

SUBSTANTIVE: religion is fixed by its OBJECT — God, gods, sacred beings. Narrow enough to exclude Buddhism BY STIPULATION, which is question-begging. → **FUNCTIONAL: religion is fixed by what it DOES — ultimacy, practice, community, meaning, liberation. Unrestricted, it admits nationalism and empties the category.** → **MULTIDIMENSIONAL: Smart's doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material dimensions. Creator-belief is NOT on the essential list.**

WHAT THE CLAUSE OWNS

- The NECESSITY question: whether creator-belief is required for religion.
- Non-theistic cases, definitions, functions, objections and costs.
- Naturalism and fictionalism only as BOUNDARY cases, never as owners.

THE FOUR DEFINITIONS AND THEIR FAILURE POINTS

- Substantive -> too narrow: decides a comparative question in advance.
- Functional (unrestricted) -> too broad: any strong commitment qualifies.
- Multidimensional -> the workable middle; family resemblance licenses it.

THE OPENING HABIT THAT DECIDES THE MARK

- Name the definition in sentence one; defend it in one line.
- Then apply it consistently — inconsistency is the commonest fault here.
- FIREWALL: rejecting a creator does not deny every deity or sacred value.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Every printed stem in this clause is decided by the definition of religion adopted in the first three lines of the script.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A personal creator is sufficient for many religions but not necessary for religion as such, provided a sacred order and a transformative practice remain.

01 · STAGE 01 THE CRITERIA LADDER: NECESSARY, SUFFICIENT AND OVER-BROAD

SEVEN CANDIDATE FEATURES · NO SINGLE NECESSARY CONDITION · DIAGNOSIS + LIBERATION = DISCRIMINATOR · WORKING SUFFICIENT CLUSTER · SACRED ORDER · SOTERIOLOGICAL PRACTICE · EXCLUDES NATIONALISM AND CARVAKA

CANDIDATE FEATURE	NECESSARY?	WHY NOT SUFFICIENT ALONE
personal creator God	NO — Buddhism, Jainism and classical Mimamsa are countercases	it defines theism, not religion as such
sacred or ultimate concern	strong candidate, very broad	nations, art and political causes can become ultimate concerns
ritual and disciplined practice	widespread, not universal in one form	secular ceremonies also have ritual
ethical orientation	common	ethical philosophies are not automatically religions
community and tradition	common	clubs and nations also organise community
DIAGNOSIS AND LIBERATION	STRONG DISCRIMINATOR	some traditions stress worship or belonging more than liberation
myth, doctrine and experience	family features	each may be thin or absent in a particular strand

THE WORKING SUFFICIENT CLUSTER

- A socially embodied and DISCIPLINED orientation to an ULTIMATE or SACRED ORDER, through doctrine, ritual, ethical formation, experience and community, directed at a TRANSFORMATIVE or SOTERIOLOGICAL goal.
- Stated as a SUFFICIENT combination, never as a list of necessary conditions.

TWO LOAD-BEARING CONDITIONS

- Sacred order AND transformative practice — both, never either alone.
- Admits Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa and Samkhya-Yoga.
- Excludes ideology as such, and excludes Carvaka.

THE CONCESSION THAT BUYS THE REPAIR

- Every functional feature over-generates on its own; concede this first.
- Then add the two conditions rather than abandoning functionalism.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The cluster is offered as a sufficient combination, which is why the counterexample hunt against necessary conditions never gets started.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religion is a disciplined orientation to a sacred order through doctrine, ritual, ethics, experience and community, directed at a transformative goal.

02 · STAGE 02 THE FUNCTION LEDGER: WHAT ACTUALLY REQUIRES A DEITY

PETITION NEEDS A HEARER · REVELATION NEEDS A SPEAKER · GRACE NEEDS A GIVER · WORSHIP DOES NOT · EFFICACY DOES NOT — APURVA · MOTIVATION DOES NOT · LIBERATION DOES NOT · SEPARABILITY RESULT

RELIGIOUS FUNCTION	PERSONAL DEITY REQUIRED?	THE NON-THEISTIC FORM
petitionary prayer	YES, normally — a responsive addressee is built into petition	meditation, aspiration or recitation, which is not petition in that sense
worship and veneration	no	reverence for Dharma, liberated exemplars, scripture or sacred value
propositional revelation from God	YES, by definition	Mimamsa has AUTHORLESS scriptural authority, not creator-revelation
grace and providence	YES, in their personal-agency sense	self-effort, karmic law, disciplined path and communal support
ritual efficacy	no	Mimamsa's unseen potency (apurva); Buddhist and Jain discipline
moral motivation	no	compassion, non-injury, karma, vows, insight, human flourishing
liberation or salvation	no, as a generic function	nirvana, Jain liberation, Samkhya-Yoga isolation (kaivalya)

WHAT THE LEDGER PROVES

- God is necessary for SOME specifically theistic goods, not for every religious function.
- Mimamsa proves inside one system that AUTHORITY, EFFICACY and DESERT are separable and can each be secured otherwise.

THE ANSWER MOVE

- Concede petition, grace and covenant openly.
- The concession buys credit for every denial that follows.
- It also locates the theist's real case: devotional, not definitional.

TRAPS AT THIS STAGE

- Do not claim God is required for nothing at all.
- Do not treat prayer and worship as one function.
- Do not say non-theistic religions 'replace' grace with self-effort.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Testing the necessity claim function by function converts an abstract dispute into a ledger the examiner can score line by line.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: God is a prerequisite for some religious goods such as petition, grace and covenant, but not for religion as such.

03 · STAGE 03 FOUR NEGATIVE POSITIONS, AND WHAT EACH LEAVES STANDING

NON-THEISM — ABOUT THE PATH · ATHEISM — ABOUT EXISTENCE · AGNOSTICISM — ABOUT KNOWLEDGE · INDIFFERENCE — NO QUESTION · ANTI-THEISM · PRACTICAL ATHEISM · THE FIREWALL OF THE CLAUSE

NON-THEISM: A CLAIM ABOUT THE PATH

- A creator is absent from a tradition's diagnosis and prescription.
- LEAVES STANDING: lesser deities, devotion, sacred value, soteriology.
- Theravada Buddhism admits cosmological devas while denying creatorhood and salvific ultimacy.

ATHEISM AND AGNOSTICISM: EXISTENCE AND KNOWLEDGE

- Atheism denies that God exists — a universal negative to be defended.
- Agnosticism suspends judgement: weak 'not known', strong 'unknowable'.
- T. H. Huxley coined the word 'agnostic' in 1869.

INDIFFERENCE, AND WHY IT IS LISTED

- The question does not arise; this is not a philosophical position.
- It appears in the list only so that it can be kept out of the answer.
- Adjacent: anti-theism and practical atheism.

THE RULE THAT GOVERNS EVERY STAGE BELOW

- NON-THEISTIC is not identical with ATHEISTIC.
- Religion survives non-theism; it does not survive the removal of every supersensible order.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The four positions differ in what they remove — a role, a knowledge claim, an existence claim and a question — and only the first leaves a religion standing.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theism concerns what a path requires, atheism what exists and agnosticism what can be known, so only the first is compatible with a constituted religion.

04 · STAGE 04 BUDDHISM I: THE DIAGNOSIS THAT NEEDS NO CREATOR

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS · PRATITYASAMUTPADA · KARMA · VACANT CREATOR SLOT · REDUNDANCY, NOT REFUTATION · AVYAKATA — RESTRICTED SCOPE · BRAHMAJALA DN 1 · AGGANNA DN 27

SUFFERING (duhkha) is the datum → **ITS ORIGIN is craving and ignorance, conditioned by dependent origination and karma** → **THE ORIGIN CAN CEASE when its conditions are removed** → **A PATH leads to that cessation — and no step of it requires a maker**

THE ARGUMENT, AND ITS EXACT STRENGTH

- Suffering arises dependently; removing the conditions removes the suffering.
- A creator adds no explanatory and no practical step to that sequence.
- The claim is REDUNDANCY, not refutation — easier to defend, and what the printed stems actually ask for.

THE GODS, AND THE UNDECLARED QUESTIONS

- Devas and Brahma figures remain IMPERMANENT beings inside samsara: neither creators nor final saviours (Brahmajala DN 1; Agganna DN 27).
- The undeclared questions (avyakata) concern specific speculative issues and are not the whole Buddhist case.
- The poisoned-arrow parable illustrates urgency, never proof of atheism.

OBJECTION AND REPLY

- OBJECTION: karma is providence renamed, since deeds still meet deserts.
- REPLY: causal-moral regularity is impersonal — nothing selects, forgives, rewards out of love or answers.
- PRESUPPOSITION to state: dependent causation suffices for the problem Buddhism addresses.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Buddhism does not refute a creator; it renders one explanatorily idle within its own diagnosis and cure.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Dependent origination and karma explain the arising and cessation of suffering, so the creator hypothesis contributes no step to the Buddhist sequence.

05 · STAGE 05 BUDDHISM II: A COMPLETE RELIGION, AND DEVOTIONAL MAHAYANA

EIGHTFOLD PATH · SILA — MORAL DISCIPLINE · SANGHA · NIRVANA · DHARMA AS SACRED ORDER · NOT ONE-FOR-ONE SUBSTITUTES · DEVOTION WITHOUT A CREATOR · 2024 Q7(a) — STATE THEN EVALUATE

THE CLUSTER, DISCHARGED ELEMENT BY ELEMENT

- Doctrine: Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, impermanence, non-self.
- Practice: the Noble Eightfold Path, meditation, monastic observance.
- Ethics: moral discipline (sila). Community: the Sangha, with rule and ordination. Goal: nirvana. Sacred order: Dharma.

THE DEVOTIONAL COMPLICATION

- WRONG: 'so Buddhism became theistic' — function mistaken for ontology.
- WRONG: 'so it must be a later corruption' — an unsupportable textual claim.
- RIGHT: Buddhas and bodhisattvas perform religious FUNCTIONS without becoming an omnipotent creator. Non-theistic does not mean devotion-free.

THE QUALIFICATION AND THE COST

- Dharma, Sangha and nirvana organise doctrine, practice and value WITHOUT working as one-for-one substitutes for a creator.
- The cost to concede: petition, covenant and grace require a responsive God.
- On a state-and-evaluate stem, complete the statement before evaluating.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The counterexample survives its own devotional development because performing a religious function is not occupying the creator role.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism satisfies every element of a multidimensional definition of religion without a creator at any point in doctrine, practice, community or goal.

06 · STAGE 06 JAINISM: MOTIVE, EMBODIMENT AND AN ACHIEVED DIVINITY

THE MOTIVE ARGUMENT · THE EMBODIMENT ARGUMENT · JIVA AND AJIVA · KARMIC MATTER · TIRTHANKARA TEACHES · SIDDHA — ACHIEVED, NOT GOVERNING · VITARAGA WORSHIP · KUMARILA'S SAME ARGUMENT FAMILY

TWO ARGUMENTS, EACH WITH PREMISES

- MOTIVE: a perfect being lacks any unfulfilled desire that creating could satisfy, so there is no motive to create.
- EMBODIMENT: acting on matter requires a body or instrument, and a body is itself made and limited.
- Same argument family as Kumarila's Slokavarttika against a bodiless agent acting upon matter.

WHAT CARRIES THE LOAD INSTEAD

- Eternal souls (jiva) and non-soul (ajiva); karmic matter that binds and is shed; vows and asceticism; liberation as the soul's own achievement.
- The ford-maker (tirthankara) teaches the path; the perfected being (siddha) has completed it. Neither creates, governs, hears nor grants.

THE THEIST'S BEST SHOT, AND THE REPLY

- OBJECTION: veneration of a passionless being is really commemoration, so Jainism is a philosophy with ceremonies.
- REPLY: commemoration of a human exemplar does not carry vows, a ritual calendar, temple practice, asceticism and a soteriological goal.
- TRAP: never describe the siddha as a creator God under another name.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Jainism is the sharpest test of worship, because it retains full veneration while removing every relational function of the object.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The Jain liberated being is an achieved perfection rather than a governing one, which shows that veneration is separable from petition.

07 · STAGE 07 MIMAMSA I: AUTHORLESS SCRIPTURE, INJUNCTION AND INTRINSIC VALIDITY

APAURUSEYA — AUTHORLESS · SVATAH-PRAMANYA · CODANA — INJUNCTION · MIMAMSA-SUTRA 1.1.2 · DEITIES AS RITUAL ELEMENTS · UDAYANA LOSES HIS PREMISE · APAURUSEYA IS NOT REVELATION

IF SCRIPTURE HAD AN AUTHOR, THREE JOBS WOULD NEED DOING — AND MIMAMSA RETIRES ALL THREE

RELIABILITY of a speaker -> retired by APAURUSEYA: the Veda is authorless, so no speaker's trustworthiness has to be established at all. → **EXTERNAL VALIDATION of authority -> retired by SVATAH-PRAMANYA: injunctions are intrinsically valid rather than validated from outside.** → **CONVENTION fixing meaning -> retired by the ETERNAL word-referent relation, which Nyaya denies as merely conventional. Note the dispute rather than settling it.**

THE DEFINITION, QUOTED FOR ITS CONSEQUENCE

- Jaimini, Mimamsa-sutra 1.1.2: codana-laksano 'rtho dharmah — dharma is what is characterised by injunction and is beneficial.
- CONSEQUENCE: dharma is known ONLY from injunction, not from perception, inference or any deity's command.
- Quoting the sutra without that consequence earns nothing.

WHAT HAPPENS TO THE THEISTIC PROOFS

- Udayana's arguments from the Veda's status lose their PREMISE rather than their conclusion.
- Deities named in the mantras are elements within the ritual structure — the dative of the oblation — not agents who hear, choose and grant.
- Kumarila's Slokavarttika argues the negative case explicitly.

THE ONE-SENTENCE TRAP

- Calling the Veda 'revelation' reinstates the divine speaker the school has just removed, and surrenders the whole counterexample.
- Revelation presupposes a revealer; authorlessness denies there is one.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Mimamsa removes God not by denying him but by withdrawing every premise on which a divine author would have been needed.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: An authorless scripture needs no speaker whose trustworthiness must first be established, so the argument from a divine author has nothing to work on.

08 · STAGE 08 MIMAMSA II: APURVA IN FIVE STEPS, AND THE TWO SCHOOLS

APURVA — THE NOT-BEFORE · ARTHAPATTI — A POSTULATE · KUMARILA: SAKTI, DESERT · PRABHAKARA: NIYOGA, DUTY · KARMADHYAKSA ANSWERED · LAW-LIKE, NOT DELIBERATIVE · CLASSICAL SYSTEM ONLY

A Vedic injunction PROMISES a result that does not follow immediately upon the act → **The act is momentary and PERISHES, and a perished cause cannot produce a later effect** → **Therefore the act generates an UNSEEN POTENCY (apurva) persisting until the fruit matures — a POSTULATE (arthapatti), never a perceived entity** → **No dispenser of karmic fruit is needed, so the Nyaya demand for a superintendent (karmadhyaksa) is answered rather than ignored**

THE TWO SCHOOLS, AND THE ETHICAL PAYOFF

- KUMARILA BHATTA: apurva is a POWER (sakti) in the act or agent linking deed to fruit — a consequential mechanism of DESERT.
- PRABHAKARA MISRA: recentres on NIYOGA / KARYA, the sheer ought-to-be-done disclosed by the injunction — a DEONTOLOGY of the injunction.
- Naming both without the desert-versus-duty payoff is name-dropping.

THREE OBJECTIONS, THREE REPLIES

- ALLOCATION (Nyaya): an unconscious potency cannot select the right fruit for the right agent -> the relation is LAW-LIKE, not deliberative, and the objection begs the question against natural law.
- MEANING: how can an authorless text mean anything -> the eternal word-referent relation, which Nyaya contests.
- BUREAUCRACY: is this religion -> sacred order, soteriological promise, disciplined practice and community.

HONEST LIMIT AND VERDICT FORMULA

- Later Mimamsa authors drift toward theism: the atheistic reading is of the CLASSICAL system, and saying so protects the answer.
- VERDICT: what Mimamsa shows is that the religious functions God performs are SEPARABLE.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — State all five steps or none, because a named potency without the perished-cause problem behind it reads as vocabulary rather than argument.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Authority, efficacy and desert are separable and can each be secured otherwise, by an authorless Veda and by a postulated potency operating as law.

09 · STAGE 09 SAMKHYA AND YOGA: A COSMOS WITHOUT A MAKER

PRAKRTI — UNCONSCIOUS, ACTIVE · PURUSA — PLURAL, CONSCIOUS · THREE GUNAS · VIVEKA-KHYATI · KAIVALYA — ISOLATION · YOGA'S ISVARA IS NOT A CREATOR · MILK AND CALF — NON-CONSCIOUS ENDS

PRAKRTI in disturbed equilibrium, in mere PROXIMITY to plural conscious selves → **EVOLUTION of intellect, ego-sense, mind, senses and the elements** → **ENTANGLEMENT: the self mistakes itself for what evolves — the predicament** → **DISCRIMINATIVE KNOWLEDGE (viveka-khyati) yields KAIVALYA, the isolation of the self from nature — release, not the annihilation of nature**

THE DISTINCTION THAT MUST BE PROTECTED

- Yoga's ISVARA is a SPECIAL SELF, untouched by affliction and action — not straightforwardly a creator in the classical Samkhya sense.
- Reading Yoga's Isvara back into Samkhya converts a non-theistic system into a theistic one by editorial accident, and destroys the counterexample.

NYAYA'S DESIGN PRESSURE, AND THE GENERAL REPLY

- OBJECTION: an unconscious principle cannot organise ENDS.
- REPLY: observed regularity need not be modelled on ARTEFACT PRODUCTION; the milk-and-calf illustration displays non-conscious purposiveness.
- This reply is the general anti-design answer of the clause, serving Buddhism and Mimamsa as well.

WHAT THE SYSTEM PRESUPPOSES

- Impersonal law or dual principles can explain order AND liberation.
- State it as a presupposition rather than smuggling it in — that is what reads as control.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A complete cosmology and a complete soteriology are built here from one unconscious principle and a plurality of conscious selves.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Samkhya shows that the demand for a maker is a demand for an extra term with no explanatory work left to do in either cosmology or liberation.

10 · STAGE 10 CARVAKA I: PERCEPTION ALONE, AND THE ATTACK ON CONCOMITANCE

PRATYAKSA ALONE IS A PRAMANA · VYAPTI — INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE · HETU AND SADHYA · REGRESS OR CIRCULARITY · UPADHI — THE RESIDUE · VYABHICARA REMAINS POSSIBLE · FOUR ELEMENTS; ETHER REJECTED · PARITY OBJECTION

BY WHAT MEANS IS INVARIABLE CONCOMITANCE (VYAPTI) ITSELF KNOWN?

NOT BY PERCEPTION — perception grasps only particular co-presences here and now, while concomitance is a UNIVERSAL covering unobserved past, future and remote cases. → **NOT BY INFERENCE — establishing it by a further inference needs that inference's own concomitance, generating INFINITE REGRESS or CIRCULARITY.** → **NOT BY TESTIMONY, and the UPADHI residue survives repetition: fire is accompanied by smoke only when the fuel is wet, so deviation remains possible.**

WHY ONLY PERCEPTION

- A means of knowledge must yield CERTAINTY about its object.
- Perception is self-evident and immediately certain.
- Every other candidate depends on a general rule perception cannot certify, so knowledge does not extend beyond the perceptible.

THE ONTOLOGY THAT FOLLOWS

- Reality is the FOUR gross elements: earth, water, fire and air.
- ETHER is rejected because it is imperceptible — a consequence, not an omission.
- The human ends reduce to pleasure and wealth, the other two requiring a supersensible order.

WHERE THE STRONG THESIS FIRST CRACKS

- PARITY: perception itself faces illusion, dream and defective organs, and is corrected only by further cognition.
- So either the certainty condition is weakened and inference re-enters, or perception fails its own test.
- Note that the conclusion is already DOMAIN-RESTRICTED in its own wording.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The directive on this module buys the argument of the critique rather than its conclusions, so the concomitance analysis is the answer.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Concomitance cannot be reached by perception, by inference or by testimony, and an unnoticed conditioning factor can never be conclusively excluded.

11 · STAGE 11 CARVAKA II: THE REPLIES, AND THE LIMITING-CASE VERDICT

DEHATMAVADA · MADASAKTI ANALOGY · SVABHAVA-VADA · SELF-REFUTATION · PRASANGA READING · PURANDARA — REPORTED STRAND · LAUKIKA VERSUS ATINDRIYA · NOT A RELIGION — THE LIMIT

THE APPLICATION TO RELIGION

- God is never perceived, so the inference to an intelligent maker is doubly worthless.
- Consciousness is EMERGENT from the body (dehatmavada), illustrated by the intoxicating power arising from combined ingredients — so no survival, no transmigration and no liberation.
- Karma and unseen merit are imperceptible props for ritual; order follows from own-nature (svabhava-vada), needing no maker.

FIVE REPLIES, AND THE TWO REJOINDERS

- Self-refutation; the pragmatic argument; Nyaya's defence by repeated uncontradicted co-observation, non-observation of a counter-instance and hypothetical reasoning; parity.
- REJOINDER A: advance the denial dialectically, as a reductio internal to the opponent's commitments.
- REJOINDER B: the REPORTED Purandara strand admits ordinary inference and denies it only for what lies beyond the senses. Flag the evidence as fragmentary and transmitted by opponents.

THE CLASSIFICATION THAT EARNS THE MARK

- Carvaka has no soteriology, no sacred, no community of practice and no ultimate concern — it is NOT a religion without God.
- Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa survive the loss of God; Carvaka closes the epistemic route to any supersensible object and ends in no religion at all.
- ATTRIBUTION: the Brhaspati verses and the hedonist couplet survive only in opponents' doxographies, chiefly Madhava's Sarvadarsanasamgraha.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The critique succeeds exactly as far as its epistemology does, so the moderate thesis is the version that remains unrefuted.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Carvaka is not a godless religion but the closure of the epistemic route to any supersensible object, and therefore the limiting case of this clause.

12 · STAGE 12 WESTERN CRITIQUES AND NIETZSCHE'S POST-THEISM

FEUERBACH — PROJECTION · MARX 1843-44 — OPIUM · FREUD — ILLUSION · COMTE — RELIGION OF HUMANITY · GENETIC EXPLANATION · ORIGIN DOES NOT SETTLE TRUTH · GOD IS DEAD — A DIAGNOSIS · OWNERSHIP GATE — 2025 Q5(c)

CRITIC	THE CLAIM	NAMED SOURCE
FEUERBACH	theology is anthropology: God is the PROJECTION of humanity's idealised essence	The Essence of Christianity
MARX	religion is the OPIUM OF THE PEOPLE, consolation masking exploitation	Introduction to A Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Right, 1843-44
FREUD	religion is an ILLUSION: wish-fulfilment and cosmic father-projection	Freud on religion as illusion
COMTE	replace the object: a positive RELIGION OF HUMANITY without a deity	Comte's Religion of Humanity
NIETZSCHE	GOD IS DEAD: collapse of the Christian-metaphysical horizon and the danger of nihilism, answered by revaluation and self-creation	The Gay Science 125, also 108 and 343; On the Genealogy of Morality

THE SHARED STRUCTURE AND THE SHARED LIMIT

- Identify a human need, show the belief would arise anyway, conclude that it is fully explained without the object.
- This BLOCKS the move from widespread belief to a real object.
- It does NOT establish that the object is absent: origin does not settle truth.

NIETZSCHE IN FOUR STEPS

- Truthfulness and science erode belief; inherited values depended on the framework; collapse creates nihilism; overcoming requires revaluation.
- Canonical example: ressentiment reverses aristocratic value terms.
- OBJECTION: revaluation risks elitism -> REPLY: creative self-overcoming, though a universal standard remains difficult.

THE OWNERSHIP GATE AND THE COMPARATIVE POINT

- The printed stem coupling religion WITH morality belongs to the Religion and Morality owner; only the post-theistic bridge is retained here.
- A horizon LOST is not a horizon NEVER HAD: Buddhism and Jainism never possessed what Nietzsche mourns, so post-theism and non-theism stay in separate paragraphs.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — These are explanatory critiques of theistic belief rather than arguments for atheism, and they must be priced accordingly.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The projection critiques claim that belief in God is fully explained without him, which blocks the inference from belief to object without removing the object.

13 · STAGE 13 AGNOSTICISM, RELIGIOUS NATURALISM AND FICTIONALISM

HUXLEY 1869 · WEAK AND STRONG AGNOSTICISM · DEWEY 1934 — THE RELIGIOUS · DWORKIN 2013 — RELIGIOUS ATHEISM · CUPITT 1980 · LE POIDEVIN 1996 · ASSERTION IS THE DIVIDING LINE · SUBLATION IS NOT FALSIFICATION · GRADED TRUTH VERSUS PRETENCE

POSITION	WHAT IT CLAIMS	NAMED ANCHOR
AGNOSTICISM	God's existence is unknown (weak) or unknowable (strong); religion and God are separable, so ethical, experiential and communal practice remains available	T. H. Huxley coins the word in 1869; Kant's practical faith and Spencer's Unknowable are adjacent
RELIGIOUS NATURALISM	ultimacy and reverence are located WITHIN nature; God names the active relation between the ideal and the actual, or drops out in favour of value realism	Dewey, A Common Faith 1934; Dworkin, Religion without God 2013; Goodenough 1998; Julian Huxley; Crosby and Rue; Spinoza as ancestor
RELIGIOUS FICTIONALISM	the claims have truth-conditions and are simply NOT ASSERTED; the practice is accepted in a fictive, non-assertoric spirit	Cupitt, Taking Leave of God 1980; Le Poidevin, Arguing for Atheism 1996; Eshleman; Wettstein
ERROR THEORY	the claims are false and the discourse should be abandoned	the contrast case that fixes what fictionalism is not
NON-COGNITIVISM	the claims never had truth-conditions at all	routed to the Religious Language owner

THE THREE OBJECTIONS TO FICTIONALISM

- INSINCERITY: worship presupposes belief; make-believe worship is dishonest or hollow -> transparent imaginative immersion is a familiar human capacity.
- MOTIVATIONAL: the practice's power derives from believing it true -> an empirical claim about narrative and ritual that remains contested.
- INTERNAL: believers reject the description, so the account is revisionary.

THE INDIAN CONTROL — DO NOT OMIT

- Advaita's everyday level (vyavaharika) worship is genuinely efficacious and is SUBLATED, not falsified, at the ultimate level (paramarthika).
- Buddhism's two truths permit full conventional practice while denying ultimate substantial reference.
- Indian systems offer GRADED TRUTH where Western fictionalism offers PRETENCE.

BOUNDED CAUTION AT THE MODERN EDGE

- Civil religion and secular spirituality are BOUNDARY TESTS, not owners.
- Without a transformative or soteriological discipline the category becomes too broad.
- Do not let this discourse crowd out the Indian cases that carry the clause.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Assertion is the dividing line: the naturalist asserts, the fictionalist declines to assert, and the error theorist abandons the discourse.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Naturalism and fictionalism show that the functions of religion are detachable from theistic belief, but whether what survives is religion depends on the opening definition.

14 · STAGE 14 SYNTHESIS: THE THEIST'S DENIAL, THE SIX-ROUTE BENCH AND THE GRADED VERDICT

FIVE THEISTIC ARGUMENTS · FIVE REBUTTALS · WORSHIP AND GRACE SURVIVE · SIX-ROUTE BENCH · SEVEN PRINTED STEMS · FOUR TOP-SCRIPT DISCRIMINATIONS · SACRED ORDER IS NOT OPTIONAL

CONSTRUCT the theist's denial first: definitional category error, worship needs a recipient, obligation needs a commander, cosmic order and karmic allotment need Nyaya's superintendent, and grace needs a giver. → **REBUT in order: Smart's dimensions against stipulation; the siddha as achieved not governing; non-theistic moral motivation; Mimamsa's authorless Veda and apurva, law-like rather than deliberative; Buddhism's complete diagnosis-and-path.** → **ASSESS honestly: the strongest SURVIVING theistic point is worship and grace, not the definition — and non-theistic religions pay a real cost in devotional structure.** → **CLOSE: religion without God is possible; religion without a SACRED ORDER is not — which is why Carvaka ends in no religion at all.**

THE SIX-ROUTE BENCH

- Buddhism (creator and permanent self removed) YES; Jainism (creator only) YES; Mimamsa (author and dispenser) STRONG under ritual definitions.
- Samkhya-Yoga (creator; Yoga keeps a non-creating Isvara) YES; modern naturalism and fictionalism ONLY on a functional definition.
- Carvaka (the whole supersensible order) NO — the limiting case.

FOUR STANDING CRITICISMS AND THEIR REPLIES

- DEFINITION -> tradition-specific and cannot accommodate established non-theistic religions.
- HIDDEN-GOD -> functional similarity does not establish ontological identity.
- MOTIVATION -> compassion, insight, karma and communal vows. NIHILISM -> Buddhist ethics, Jain vows and humanist normativity, whose objectivity still requires argument.

THE FOUR DISCRIMINATIONS THAT MARK A TOP SCRIPT

- Non-theistic is not atheistic; authorless is not revelation.
- Sublation is not falsification; Carvaka is the limit, not an instance.
- Plus the concession that petition and grace genuinely require a responsive God.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Half the marks on the opponent-construction stem lie in building the theist's case properly before a single word of rebuttal is written.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religion without God is not merely conceivable but actual, while religion without a sacred order is not, which is why the limiting case ends in no religion.

E · EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH · IMPERSONAL LAW VERSUS INTELLIGENT CAUSE · POST-THEISM VERSUS NIHILISM · FICTIONALIST SINCERITY · UNPROMOTED FOUR-WAY COMPARISON · ONE MOVE AT 15 MARKS

SECOND-ORDER DISPUTES ONLY

- A1 impersonal law against intelligent causation: purposive order is said to need an agent; the reply denies that regularity must be modelled on artefact production.
- A2 Nietzschean post-theism against nihilism: value-creation without an external standard risks arbitrariness, and the self-reference is acknowledged rather than escaped.

THE RESIDUE LEFT BY THE PROMOTION LEDGER

- A3 whether a fictionalist can SINCERELY inhabit a practice she declines to assert, given that prayer is an address rather than a mere expression.
- A4 the systematic four-way comparison of Buddhism, Jainism, Mimamsa and Samkhya, which the dossier will promote only if a printed question asks it.

DEPLOYMENT DISCIPLINE

- Add ONE advanced move to a fifteen-marker, or one to two at twenty marks.
- Never before the owner's own material is on the page, and never in place of Buddhism, Jainism or the Indian anti-creator arguments.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This block is subordinate enrichment and is unnecessary for a competent core answer on any of the seven printed stems.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels